

Photographs: AFP



VAIBHAV SURYAVANSHI, *13*

***Batsman*, Rajasthan Royals**

Thirteen years old and a Rs 1.1 crore contract to play for IPL franchise Rajasthan Royals, this is the stuff cricketing dreams are made of. Bihar born Suryavanshi, the youngest player ever in the IPL, has been trying hard to live up to the hype. Last year saw a 58-ball hundred against Australia in an Under-19, a blistering 71 runs playing for Bihar in the Vijay Hazare Trophy, and 176 runs in the Asia U-19 tournament. The intent is clear, is he ready now to play for bigger stakes?

JACOB BETHELL, *21*

***Batter*, Royal Challengers Bengaluru**

When he was 11, Bethell was told he was better than Brian Lara at the same age. The compliment, incidentally, came from the legend himself. Another big name emerging from the England coaching system, Bethell is all set to light up IPL 2025 for RCB. In his overall T20I career, Bethell has impressed with a strike-rate of close to 150. The Barbados born batter had a terrific 2024, turning out for England in all three formats of the game. If RCB elects to use his prowess to the fullest, then the 21-year-old could prosper.



NAMAN DHIR, *25*

***Batter*, Mumbai Indians**

When the IPL's most successful franchise decides to retain you, you know you have done something right. Mumbai Indians used the RTM (Right To Match) card to retain Naman Dhir in the mega auction, even though the youngster from Ambala did not have a very good Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy outing in 2024, averaging just 22. For MI, though, his knocks, such as the power-packed 62 off 28 balls in 2023 against Lucknow Super Giants, are reason enough for his top billing. Will this be the season where Naman's potential meets peak consistency?